

The Heart of the Tantra Called the Glorious Wheel of Time

Śrī Kālacakra Garbha Nāma Tantra · Toh 364 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་དམུ་གཉིས་པོ་ལ་ཞེས་བ་བྱལ་རིམ་གཉིས་པོ་

Toh 364 in the Kangyur is a tantric text known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Kālacakra Garbha Nāma Tantra and in Tibetan as the Dpal Dus Kyi 'Khor Lo Zhes Bya Ba'i Rgyud Kyi Snying Po, rendered in English as The Heart of the Tantra Called the Glorious Wheel of Time. It belongs to the Kālacakra cycle, one of the most elaborate and celebrated traditions within Vajrayāna Buddhism, dealing with cosmology, time, the subtle body, and the path to liberation through tantric practice. The text is cast in the form of a tantra, opening with a homage to Mañjuśrī and a request by King Candrabhadra, and it presents in condensed verse the essential teachings of the Wheel of Time system, including meditative absorption, vital energies, and the means of liberation particularly suited to an age of strife. As the "heart" or essence of the broader Kālacakra Tantra, it distills key doctrinal and practical elements of that tradition and is preserved among the tantric scriptures of the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Śrī Kālacakra Garbha Nāma Tantra. In the Tibetan language: The Heart of the Tantra Called the Glorious Wheel of Time.

Homage to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

The wisdom body of omniscience,
Like the radiance of the sun,
With eyes like lotus petals,
The buddha abides upon a lion throne.
Worshipped by the highest of gods,
I bow, touching my crown in homage.

King Candrabhadra made this request.
The joined limb of the lotus:
having placed it upon the highest limb,
the practice of the Wheel of Time
in the age of strife
is the cause of liberation for human beings.

The ten aspects of the gathering
become the sovereign faculty of the Victors.

Likewise, the dhyāna of the unshakeable,
together with vitality and exertion bearing a sword —
again in ten forms,
holding the seal of precious things —
the subsequent mindfulness of the servant
becomes the holder of the lotus.

The glorious meditative absorption that is the wheel:
divide each of these further into five.
Again, whatever is divided —
those beginning with A and those beginning with Ka —
the ten aspects of the gathering, both object and subject,
are without entry into the body.

Wisdom is discernment and investigation.
Joy, the unshakeable, bliss,
and dhyāna: the mind is one-pointed.

The path of vitality and exertion
becoming unagitated
is the entry of vitality into the central channel.
Vitality enters into the drop,
and both the going and the coming —
the apprehending mind being unified —
whatever luminosity of the fierce woman (caṇḍālī)
arises clearly in the body,
that sky comes to be subsequently recalled.

Through the power of the co-emergent truth
of the nature of wisdom and skillful means,
the wisdom body is the meditative absorption.
This, through the distinctions of water and so forth,
comes to be threefold —
the sādhana of the lord of the variety.

Through the sovereign power of the three mudrās,
the three measures, and the three aspects,
the gathering-practice yogi of wholesome action
and noble ideation
is completely free in the domain of objects,

consecrated by all mantras,
and through pure meditative practice
will attain the five superknowledges.

Through purity of vitality and exertion,
through purity free of moon and sun,
worshipped by bodhisattvas,
through the power of holding,
overcoming the māras of affliction and so forth,
one enters into the ten powers.

The immaculate radiating maṇḍala —
this too arises from the wisdom body.
Therefore through pure meditative absorption,
even in a brief moment like a single day,
the wisdom body will be accomplished.

If one comes to be tormented
by the gathering practice and so forth,
the aims of the mantra practitioners will not be fulfilled.
Accustomed to sound through the articulation of the auxiliary limbs —
Pad, Song, Vajra, Jewel —
let the accomplishment of the drop proceed.

The approach and the first union:
in the sky, in ten forms,
the one bearing a wheel has a wrathful gaze.
The view that is the destroyer of obstructors,
and also the going of ambrosia along the path —
the six limbs of the close approach.
The moon-drop arisen from wisdom,
and also vajra and jewel —
three syllables are to be accomplished.
Bliss undiminished, unified, pacified,
becomes the co-emergent.
This is the practice of great accomplishment, the wisdom union.

Vitality and exertion, from all sides
up to the head, are beneficial.
Bestowing the fruit of equal bliss —

beyond that, they are not beneficial
and become the agents of the destruction of death.
This is the cause of the definitive liberation of sentient beings.

Through the gate of the uṣṇīṣa, from within the hollow,
to the rank of supreme bliss:
this is what is to be joined and done.

The yoginī free of the aggregates,
though she dwells in equal bliss,
is still without worldly renown.
The entry of vitality into the center,
being utterly free of objects —
she who is embraced by the manifold mother:
the self-vajra entering into the lotus,
enthusiasm too is likewise.

The vajra is to be placed at the center. Bliss in which the seed does not fall —
gone into the attachment of utter attachment,
the very union of the yogin:
the lord supremely all-pervading,
the fierce one, secret among secrets,
at the uṣṇīṣa the five-pointed —
this is the transformation of the vajra.

At the outer tip, in twofold transformation,
the transformation is the maṇḍala of Dharma.
That is the mingling of the two,
and that again is twofold transformation.
Of that too, another is twofold transformation.
The innate and the perfect enjoyment:
this is the emanation wheel.
Within that is the single-pointed.

The giver of the fruit of equal bliss —
the secret within the secret lotus:
the yogin and the life-cutter,
divided into day and night,
this is declared to be the terror of life.

Whatever sound is without voice,
arising supremely in the heart —
that is falsehood itself.

Whatever distinction is grasped
in the domain of omniscient wisdom:
that is declared to the yogin.

The bliss-drop that does not fall
becomes another's woman.
Reliance without attachment it is not.

By the fire of vitality and exertion,
dissolving in the one bearing the hare —
the drinking is the drinking of beer.

From the joint of the thumb up to the uṣṇīṣa,
moving by the power of the lunar days,
one's own mind reaches its end like a fish.
From the uṣṇīṣa down to the thumb,
again here it moves —
reaching the far end of the dark direction.

The yoginī who practices thus
gives forth the desired attainments
at the time of each single day.

When the body is hot from the practice and from desire,
from the supreme lotus of the mouth:
speechlessness, and sleep,
trembling, illness, muteness,
mental agitation, and fainting,
smoke and so forth — the vajra-bearer:
these ten, as luminous appearances,
are the states of the body of a living being.
The states of worldly desire
are clearly understood from certainty alone.

Who is the Victor, and what is desired?
What is the flow of the white drop?
Falling by day and by night —
Māmakī cuts that off.

Gokula and so forth, the eyes and so forth —
delighting at each single day:
none whatsoever is other flesh.

Relying on the five nectars,
one has gone to the ground of one's own family —
from the pure body of the gods.

By strife, that mind of emptiness,
with innate all-pervading bliss:
there is no birth-place coupling for that.

The giving away of a gift of wealth,
and toward union with a woman, in mind
the non-emission is moral discipline.

Patience is the non-engagement with sound and so forth.
The laziness that goes in both directions —
its utter destruction is diligence.

Meditative concentration, wisdom, mind,
and going into bliss as innate:
all-pervasive — this is the expression of all.

For the benefit of sentient beings that magical power
renders the aim of existence meaningless.
The other attainment gained is the fourth.

Capable in a single body,
together with the nine parts,
twenty-five self-natures and so forth —
the very pair of dhyāna and mudrā:
by a single day of even slight practice,
authentic attainments will arise.

Pacification, domination, and inflation,
and the destruction of existence —
divided and distinguished by the mouth,
dwelling in the maṇḍala of the elements,
the families of asuras and serpents:
having meditated on this, it is to be accomplished.

This is an excerpt from the Glorious Kālacakra, spoken from the glorious
primordial buddha of twelve thousand verses, from the section on the sādhana

of the method of the six-branched yoga, on the non-duality of method and wisdom.

Translated by the Indian master Śrī Bhadrabodhi and the Tibetan translator and monk Dawa Özer.

Translator's Notes

- The text is the opening of the Kālacakra Laghu Tantra, specifically its condensed version known as the Kālacakra Garbha or Heart Tantra of the Wheel of Time. The passage is highly technical Kālacakra Vajrayāna terminology and moves rapidly through enumerated categories of yogic practice. Several terms carry highly specialized Kālacakra-system meanings: "gathering" renders so so sdud pa, which in the Kālacakra system refers to a specific meditative technique of withdrawing the senses; the "ten aspects" and the divisions into five relate to the Kālacakra six-limbed yoga system; "vitality and exertion" renders srog and rtsol ba, the Kālacakra equivalents of prāṇa and apāna; and "fierce woman" for gtum mo is the inner heat practice. The phrase "moon and sun" refers to the left and right channels. The names Pad, Song, Vajra, Jewel are seed-syllable sequences specific to the Kālacakra system whose full technical referents are defined in the root and explanatory tantras. The "servant" for g.yung mo is a specific class of practitioner or a feminine deity-form in the Kālacakra mandala hierarchy; both renderings are defensible. The phrase "ten aspects of the wheel-bearing one with wrathful gaze" in the approach section refers to the ten wrathful deities of the Kālacakra maṇḍala.

- The phrase rendered "the one bearing the hare" refers to the moon, a standard literary kenning in Sanskrit and Tibetan poetic convention: the moon is said to bear the image of a hare on its face. In context the line describes the dissolution of the vital drop in the moon, a standard Kālacakra yogic image.

The term "Māmakī" is a tantric goddess, one of the wisdom-consorts (the consort of Akṣobhya in the Vajrayāna maṇḍala), whose function here is to sever the downward flow of the white drop, a specifically Kālacakra physiological-soteriological image.

The colophon names the Kālacakra Tantra in its extensive version of twelve thousand verses, attributed to the primordial buddha Ādibuddha, and records the standard Tibetan translation team attribution.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of

stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.